

Supermarine Spitfire

"SOME MEN FALL IN LOVE WITH YACHTS," said RAF fighter pilot Bob Stanford-Tuck, "or some with women... or motor cars, but I think every Spitfire pilot fell in love with it as soon as he sat in that nice tight cozy office [RAF slang for cockpit] with everything to hand." Responsive to a touch of the fingertips on the joystick, or the feet on the rudder pedals, the Spitfire was a joy for a good pilot to fly.

Prototyped in 1936, the Spitfire went into production in 1938. Its quality depended on a marriage between an imaginative airframe design and a superb new engine, the Rolls Royce Merlin. Incorporating all the most advanced features of aircraft of its day – adjustable-pitch propeller, all-metal monocoque construction, retractable undercarriage, enclosed cockpit – it achieved uniqueness through its elliptical wing. This ingeniously solved the problem of housing eight machine guns and a retractable undercarriage, while providing enough strength to withstand the stress of high-speed maneuvers.

The Spitfire had a few drawbacks. Its novel wing initially posed problems for mass

"The Spitfire had style and was obviously a killer."

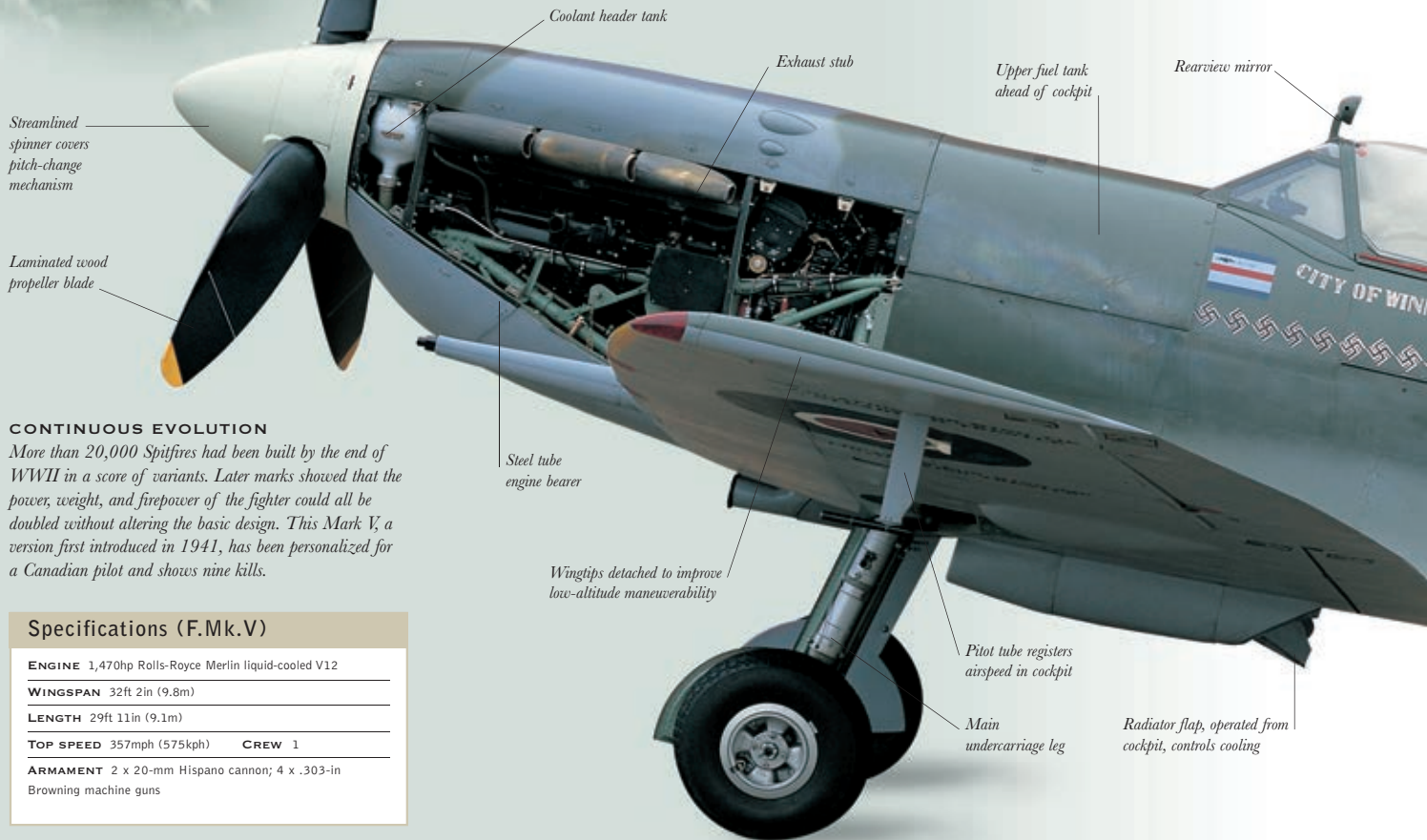
"SAILOR" MALAN

CO 74 SQUADRON AND BATTLE OF BRITAIN ACE

production; the pilot could not see in front of the aircraft when taxiing; and the engine had a habit of cutting out going into a dive, because negative gravity cut off the fuel supply – a problem the Messerschmitt's fuel-injected engine did not have. But the overall quality of Mitchell's design was proven by the Spitfire's ability to hold its own up to the end of the war.

WOMEN'S WORK

Women of the WAAF (Women's Auxiliary Air Force) prepare to close the side hatch through which the pilot entered the cockpit. Every pilot was dependent upon the support of ground crew.



CONTINUOUS EVOLUTION

More than 20,000 Spitfires had been built by the end of WWII in a score of variants. Later marks showed that the power, weight, and firepower of the fighter could all be doubled without altering the basic design. This Mark V, a version first introduced in 1941, has been personalized for a Canadian pilot and shows nine kills.

Specifications (F.Mk.V)

ENGINE 1,470hp Rolls-Royce Merlin liquid-cooled V12

WINGSPAN 32ft 2in (9.8m)

LENGTH 29ft 11in (9.1m)

TOP SPEED 357mph (575kph) **CREW** 1

ARMAMENT 2 x 20-mm Hispano cannons; 4 x .303-in Browning machine guns